address the Congress. We feel, too, his fear at nightfall and darkness; when he has to mix with the Indian elite; when trying to make his career as lawyer; and perhaps most painfully, in the trivial, everyday routines of life. Buying a train ticket, travelling, puzzling over how to dress himself, even the act of walking down a street – all are liable to induce terror in Gandhi. Gandhi's narrative voice sometimes seems to affect a jaunty, almost Pollyanna-ish tone. Yet this is deceptive. For Gandhi's experience is that of a man cast into a world in which he has to wage a constant battle to steady himself: a world where both the traditional, with its superstitions and rituals, and the modern, with its choices framed by colonial power, appear intimidating.

Gandhi mastered his fears through a discovery. By blurring the lines and shifting the barriers between the public and private realms – the core distinction of liberal theory and practice, and of the modern state and its law – he could generate unprecedented powers, and so undermine his opponents. As he saw it, modern politics – which, in his vivid image, encircled everything like the coil of a snake – had constricted and separated the domains of private ethics and public action. The means to reunite the two, as well as to draw the poison of modern politics, was to turn his own life inside out. The details of his life were thus constantly witnessed and recorded – befitting, perhaps, for a barrister whose language, manners, and theatrical sense of confrontation were all shaped by his encounter with British law. Gandhi extended an open invitation to fellow Indians (both elite and poor), to the British, and to the world at large, to eavesdrop on him at any and every moment. Paradoxically – and in a supreme subversion of